

Benjamin R. Westlund

UX Researcher · PhD Student, Health Behavior

University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill — Gillings School of Global Public Health — Department of Health Behavior — 170 Rosenau Hall, Chapel Hill, NC 27599 — 919-808-7196 — benwestlund@med.unc.edu — linkedin.com/in/benwestlund

EDUCATION

PhD, Health Behavior

UNC Gillings School of Global Public Health

Faculty advisor: Dr. Vivian Go · Dorothy Dunn Scholar

Expected May 2029

MSPH, Health Behavior

UNC Gillings School of Global Public Health

Dorothy Dunn Scholar

Expected December 2026

B.A., Sociology

Wake Forest University

2018 — 2022

Major: Sociology, Social Determinants of Health and Well-being · Minor equivalent: Health and Exercise Science · Cum Laude, Honors and Distinction in Sociology

RESEARCH & DESIGN EXPERIENCE

Graduate Research Assistant

Department of Health Behavior, UNC Gillings School of Global Public Health

Rural opioid harm-reduction research (OHOP), provider alcohol use in Vietnam, implementation strategy tracking, and emergency preparedness planning. Qualitative coding and analysis in NVivo and Dedoose, survey instrument development, theory-driven memo writing, and mixed-methods integration.

Aug 2024 — Present

Human-Centered Design Lead — TABLE

TABLE, Orange County NC (semester-long engagement)

Led a full human-centered design cycle with a local food-security nonprofit: designed and facilitated listening sessions and card sorts with 17 participants, built empathy maps and insight statements, ran co-ideation workshops, and prioritized concepts with a value/effort matrix. Presented three validated concepts and an assumption-testing plan to organizational leadership.

2025

Research & Program Support Specialist

NC Formerly Incarcerated Transition Program (NC FIT), UNC Family Medicine

Supported clinical reentry navigation for formerly incarcerated individuals through care coordination, data tracking, and Medicaid suspension/reactivation. Contributed to program evaluation, qualitative interviews, county stakeholder communication, and strategic partnership development.

Aug 2022 — Jul 2024

Senior Honors Thesis Researcher

Wake Forest University

Designed and led an independent qualitative study on the intersection of COVID-19 and opioid use disorder. Conducted interviews, completed thematic analysis, and authored a grant-winning thesis.

Aug 2021 — May 2022

Research Assistant

Center for Health Policy and Inequalities Research (CHPIR)

HRV intervention research, literature reviews, qualitative memo development, and data management.

May — Aug 2021

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Teaching Assistant

Wake Forest University — Undergraduate Sociology

Supported course design, graded writing assignments, and led mini lectures for an undergraduate sociology seminar.

Aug — Dec 2021

SKILLS & METHODS

- UX & Design Research: Human-centered design facilitation, listening sessions, card sorting, empathy mapping, insight synthesis, How-Might-We framing, co-ideation workshops, value/effort prioritization, wireframing & prototyping, usability testing, Miro
- Qualitative: Thematic analysis, grounded theory, memo writing, codebook development, NVivo, Dedoose
- Quantitative: Stata, survey design, data management
- Mixed Methods: Joint displays, integration, hybrid designs
- Implementation Science: CFIR, ERIC, barrier/strategy matrices, implementation strategy tracking

PUBLICATIONS

PRE-PUBLISHED

Emergency Preparedness Planning: Lessons from COVID-19 and the Opioid Crisis in Rural Ohio

Westlund BR, Sibley AL, Colston DC, Devadas J, Enderle MN, Piscalko HM, Miller WC, Go VF

DOI: [10.64898/2026.07.30.26359388](https://doi.org/10.64898/2026.07.30.26359388)

ACCEPTED FOR PRESENTATION — SIRC 2026

When is the Juice Worth the Squeeze? Costs Versus Benefits of Implementation Strategy Tracking

Westlund B, Powell B, Dang HLT, Cao TVA, Nguyen HN, Nguyen KN, Sripaipan T, Rossi SL, Miller WC, Go VF, Bartels SM

MANUSCRIPT IN PREPARATION

Healthcare Providers' Own Use in Vietnam: A Socioecological Analysis of Motivations, Barriers, and Facilitators to Drinking

Westlund B, et al.

IN PROGRESS

Human-Centered Design × Implementation Science: A Scoping Review

Supporting author

FELLOWSHIPS AND AWARDS

- Dorothy Dunn Scholarship, UNC Gillings School of Global Public Health, 2024
- Faculty-Student Facilitation Fund Grant Award, Wake Forest University, 2022

RESEARCH GRANTS

- Westlund, B. & Brewer, A. (advisor). The Intersection of the Opioid Crisis and the COVID-19 Pandemic; Wake Forest University, Faculty-Student Facilitation Fund Grant Award, \$200, funded.

MEMBERSHIPS AND AFFILIATIONS

- American Public Health Association (APHA) — Early Career Professional
- North Carolina Public Health Association
- Society for Implementation Research Collaboration (SIRC) — 2026 presenter